PROPOSAL · 13 OCTOBER 2026 · SOHO SQUARE GARDENS, W1D 3QH

The Scent Vault

Variant C · a perfume museum beneath Soho Square

Below the lawn there is a 300 m^2 machine hall: a 1928 DC converter substation that became a Blitz shelter, sealed since about 2015. This proposal turns it into a small, hosted perfume museum with a London flagship for Tiziana Terenzi. This page sets out one of four design directions, with its floor plan and long section.



SOHO SQUARE GARDENS · 1132

FLOOR

297 m²

3,200 sq ft, 2015 particulars

PLAN

30 × 10 m

estimate, east–west

DEPTH

3.5–4.5 m

below the lawn, estimate

BUILT

1928

substation, WWII shelter

STAIRS

2

west hatch + Grade II hut

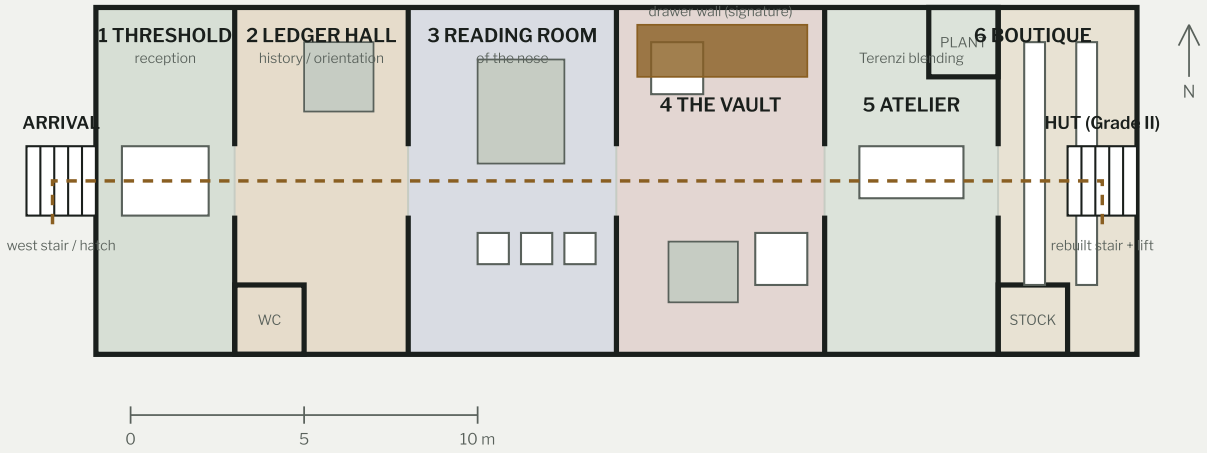
VISITORS

60–70

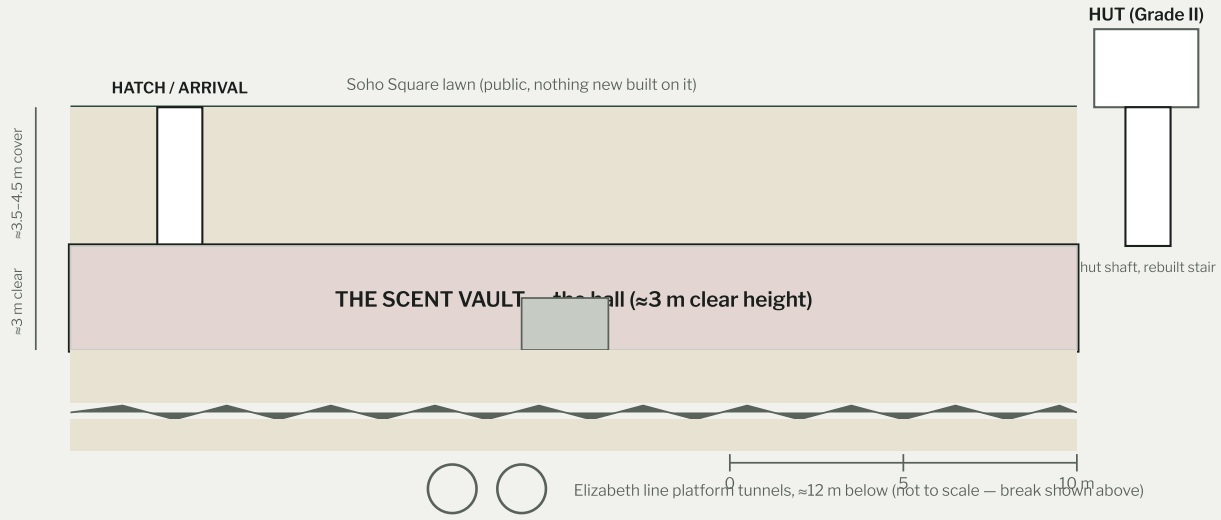
at once, both stairs rebuilt

The Scent Vault

A bank for smells you can't get back, and one drawer, with your name on it, that's yours.



Floor plan, 1:200 at 20 px/m. 30 × 10 m hall, about 297 m^2. West stair = arrival, hut stair = second exit.



Long section, west to east. Depths are estimates until measured.

The idea

The shelter was built to hold a 1920s substation's cables and plinths, then became a wartime refuge, then stood bricked up for years. The Scent Vault treats it as what the brick and steel already look like underground: a strongroom. Visitors open an account on arrival, are issued a brass key, and walk a ledger-to-vault sequence that ends in a wall of hundreds of keyed safe-deposit drawers, each holding

a scent that can't be smelled anywhere else, discontinued formulas, reconstructions of historic ones, a rotating "smell of London" archive. Members go further: they deposit a personal, bespoke fragrance formula, built with a Terenzi perfumer, sealed, numbered and stored in their own drawer, exactly as a bank stores a document. It is calm, precise and archival rather than theatrical, a museum that behaves like an institution you can trust with something irreplaceable.

The visit, room by room

1. **Threshold** (3 min) — Reception at the foot of the west hatch, styled as a bank's entrance lobby: a teller-style desk, soft brass light, a single leather ledger. You give your name, are issued a brass token and a blank blotter card. Smell: nothing yet, deliberately, a neutral scrubbed-air lobby so the nose resets from the street.
2. **The Ledger Hall** (7 min) — Orientation room. The substation's own history (1928 converter station, WWII refuge, the "SOHO SQUARE GARDENS 1132" door) told via relics on an original machine plinth, kept as-found behind glass. A short audio piece, no screens. Smell: cold stone, machine oil, a trace of wartime wool, there to place you underground before the perfume starts.
3. **The Reading Room for the Nose** (12 min) — A hushed library: armchairs, a wall of glass smelling domes (Osmothèque method, no diffusion, no contamination), paper blotters you keep. One original sunken machine pit is kept open as a display well. You read short cards and smell discontinued perfumes, extinct raw materials (real ambergris, oakmoss before IFRA limits, synthetic musks that got banned) and early 20th-century London itself: coal smoke, chypre face powder, Thames fog.
4. **The Vault** (15 min) — The signature room. A brass drawer wall along the north wall, your key opens one numbered drawer at a time. Behind it: the "smell of London" rotating collection (fog, wet Berwick Street market, a 1940 shelter night) and a locked tier of members' private deposits, visible, unreachable, exactly like walking past other people's safe-deposit boxes. A vault keeper (not a shop assistant) hosts this room.
5. **The Atelier** (15 min) — Tiziana Terenzi's blending bench. Workshop guests build and bottle their own 30–50 ml scent here. Members who choose to "deposit" go through the full ceremony: formula agreed with the perfumer, decanted, wax-sealed, logged in the ledger, given a numbered brass pendant that is also their vault key.
6. **The Boutique** (10–15 min, unticketed dwell) — Terenzi's range, archive-inspired capsule bottles, and the hut stair exit (second, protected escape route, rebuilt to current standard).

The signature moment

Opening your own drawer in the Vault wall with the key you were given at the door: a cold brass cylinder, a quiet mechanical give, and a scent that exists nowhere else you can go. Members get a second version of this forever, the 400th visit is still "my drawer, my scent".

Making it super cool

- **Keyed brass safe-deposit wall**: hundreds of individually sealed cylinders, each a closed system (one blotter reservoir, no open diffusion), so the signature device is also the HVAC-safest one in the building.
- **The Ledger**: every visit and every deposit logged by hand in a bound ledger with a wax seal, a single continuous institutional record rather than a stamped ticket.
- **Smelling domes, not nebulisers**: the Reading Room uses sealed glass domes and blotters exclusively, so the library never cross-contaminates the Vault next door.
- **Sound as asset, not problem**: Northern/Elizabeth line rumble and the brass drawers' own mechanical clunk are leaned into as ambient "vault sound", not masked.
- **As-found heritage window**: one section of WWII brick and the fuse box plinth kept visible behind glass in the Ledger Hall, everywhere else lined and sealed per conservation/HVAC need.
- **Deposit ceremony**: wax seal, numbered brass pendant, ledger entry, the single most giftable and photographable private ritual in the building.
- **Quarterly rotating archive**: the "smell of London" tier changes every season, so locals re-visit; each scent carries a citation card (archival, not invented).
- **Light and material grammar**: cool bank-vault white light in the Vault, warm library amber in the Reading Room, brass/walnut/glass/inert tile throughout, no plastic, nothing loud.

Above ground

Arrival is through the existing west hatch, discreetly marked, a small brass plaque at the railings reading only "The Scent Vault, by appointment", no banners, no queue barriers. Entry is by named, timed appointment (like a bank), so nobody waits outside in the square. The Grade II hut is rebuilt as the second, protected stair, used for exit only (and step-free access via a platform lift in its shaft, per the dossier's Scenario C precedent), so no new footprint on the lawn and no gathering at the hut doors. Garden etiquette: visitors leave individually or in loose pairs, no grouped dispersal, no signage beyond the one plaque, planting around the hatch kept as is.

Formats & money

All figures are estimates, built on the dossier's comparators, and will move ±30–50% until the space is surveyed.

TICKET	PRICE (INCL. VAT)	WHAT IT IS
Vault Pass (self-guided, Rooms 1–4 + boutique)	£28	Reading Room + Vault only, no host
Hosted Vault Tour (all 6 rooms, 60 min)	£38	Groups of 12, host-led, the core product
Nocturne (flameless candlelight, non-alcoholic pairing)	£65	Evening slots, 2 a night
Atelier Workshop (build your own 30–50 ml)	£145	With a Terenzi perfumer, 8 per session
Deposit Ceremony (one-off, non-member)	£950	Bespoke formula, sealed, one-year drawer storage included

Membership (the private-club layer): Vault Membership, £480/year — a permanent personal drawer, unlimited Reading Room access, member evenings, priority deposit-ceremony booking, and discounted re-formulation if a stored scent needs rebalancing. This is the recurring-revenue spine the research flags as missing from a pure ticket model.

Non-obvious revenue line: the Bequest Service. A member can leave standing instructions for their drawer, released to family on death, donated to the public "smell of London" archive, or destroyed, administered for a one-off £150 filing fee plus the ledger entry. It fits the institution's own conceit (a bank handles bequests) and turns the vault into something people plan around rather than just visit.

Private hire: whole-Vault buyouts for brand launches, weddings (a couple can commission and deposit "the smell of our wedding" as a live event centrepiece), £2,800–£4,200 an evening.

Terenzi's role: runs the Atelier and Boutique as operator/concession (so retail margin of roughly 75–85% sits with Terenzi), supplies the perfumer for every Deposit Ceremony, and the Boutique sells an archive-inspired capsule range exclusive to the Vault.

Capacity, following the dossier's Scenario B/C (rebuilt west stair + rebuilt hut stair, cap ≈60–70 at once): groups of 12 every 30 min across 10 day slots ≈ 37k hosted places/year; plus Reading Room self-guided passes and the boutique. **Rough net revenue, mid case: ≈£1.8m–£2.2m/year** (hosted journeys + nocturnes + atelier + membership + boutique + bequest fees), broadly in line with the dossier's £2.0m mid-case, with membership and bequest fees adding a thin but sticky layer on top. **Estimate, unverified.**

Fit with the constraints

- **Fire:** needs Scenario B/C (rebuilt west stair ≥1000 mm *and* the hut shaft rebuilt as a protected stair) to use the full 30 m plan and lift the 18 m travel-distance limit; under Scenario A only, Rooms 5–6 (Atelier, Boutique, hut exit) would sit outside the usable zone, a real risk if the second stair isn't achievable. Occupancy stays under the ~60–70 cap by design (groups of 12, staggered).
- **Heritage:** machine plinths and one brick/concrete bay kept visible as-found; everything else lined per HVAC need. Hut touched only for the stair/lift, both needing Listed Building Consent.
- **HVAC:** the Vault's sealed-drawer design is the safest-possible olfactory device (no open diffusion); Reading Room uses blotters/domes only; Atelier is the one room needing full DSEAR-compliant alcohol handling (dummy flacons on display, ≤50 L cabinet, bulk stock off-site).
- **Accessibility:** step-free only if a platform lift fits the hut shaft (unverified, needs a measured survey); fallback is a surface/virtual Vault experience and a take-home scent kit, as the dossier's Clapham South precedent suggests.

Risks

- The whole plan leans on the second escape route existing; if only Scenario A is achievable, the Atelier and Boutique (and the signature Vault drawer wall, if placed east of 18 m) may not fit.
- Membership and the Bequest Service promise long-term custody of physical scent and legal instructions, real reputational and insurance exposure if a stored fragrance degrades or a bequest is mishandled; needs proper underwriting, not just a ledger.
- Underground damp and cool temperatures (good for scent storage) require dehumidification running year-round for the brass vault wall and sealed drawers; any plant failure threatens the stored collection, not just comfort.

Prepared by Mia for Alessandro Ticchi, 13/10/2026. Dimensions are estimates from photographs and 2015 press reports. Nothing here has been measured. Site photos: 28DaysLater, Forever Changes, Subterranea Britannica, Evening Standard (2015). Revenue figures are rough estimates for discussion.